SEND WITH THE SCRIPT

Self-recording guide

Reality-TV confessional style: you sit and talk to the camera, deadpan. No interviewer, so prop up your own phone, or let whoever sent you this hold it, and record it in five minutes whenever you have a free moment.

Setup

- **Nobody films you.** Prop your phone horizontal against a stack of books or a mug, at face height, about an arm's length away. Sit in a chair against a plain wall or a bookshelf.
- **Light:** face a window or a lamp. Don't sit with a window behind you.
- **Eyeline:** look just to the side of the lens, as if a producer is sitting next to the phone. Glancing at the lens once or twice is fine.
- **Tone:** deadpan beats hammy. You are a sincere person who has nothing to hide and is slightly annoyed to be asked.

Recording

- **The script:** read it from a second screen or a printout taped just under the phone. The *(beat)* and *(pause)* marks are where the laughs live. Hold them longer than feels natural.
- **Takes:** two max. Send the slightly flubbed one. Don't edit anything.
- **Length:** 60 to 90 seconds. Start recording, wait two seconds, begin. Stop two seconds after the last line.
- **Send it:** text or AirDrop the raw video to whoever sent you the script. They add the title card and load it onto the classroom laptop.

Making the script yours

Words in [brackets] are adjustable. The box at the top of your script sorts them: a few **must match the case file** (your clothing color, the time, a shoe size), because the kids cross-check what you say against printed evidence; if one of those is wrong for you, tell whoever sent you this before recording and it gets changed everywhere. Your clothing color only has to be true for "yesterday": wear it on camera if you can, but the lines work if you can't. The rest is flavor. Swap in your real life, your real subject, your real habits. True details get the biggest laughs.

The ask (email or text to each suspect)

Subject: 5 minutes of acting for the 4th grade Halloween party?

Hi [Name],

Mrs. Driscoll's class Halloween party on Oct 30 is a whodunit, and the kids are going to investigate four staff "suspects." Would you be one of the three who record a statement? All it takes is a 90-second video of yourself that you can record alone on your phone whenever you have a free minute. No one films you, no one edits you, and you don't need to attend the party.

Attached is your script. It's a monologue, so just talk to the camera. Quick tips:
• Phone horizontal, propped at face height, plain wall behind you
• Look just beside the lens, like a producer is sitting there
• Deadpan. Sincere. Slightly annoyed to be asked.
• Hold the pauses. Two takes max. Send me the raw video by [Oct 23].

The kids will watch it on the projector during the party and, I promise, lose their minds. Thank you!

[Your name] · [room parent for Mrs. Driscoll's class] · [phone]

The Custodian gets a different ask: "You're a suspect who declined to comment. That's it. That's the whole job. Please act shifty in the hallway on Oct 30."

VIDEO 3 · PLAYS AFTER STATION 3

VIDEO 3 — THE LIBRARIAN

self-recorded monologue, ~75 sec, WHISPERED throughout · Zero information, whispered throughout. Accidentally sounds guilty three times.

TITLE CARD · INTERVIEW 3 · THE LIBRARIAN · 12:30 PM

MAKE IT YOURS (read before you record)

- Must match the case file: you were "in the building" at [2:15] (your [2:00 to 2:30] shelving window has to include it), you were wearing [orange] yesterday (same color as the ransom note and the posters; the room parent owns that color), and you love squishies. Wear the color on camera if you can; the lines work either way. Your shoe size is the one thing that clears you, so don't mention a number on camera.
- Free to change: [shelving] (any solo task you really do), [on every cart], why it's stressful, [alphabetized] (any librarian joke you like better).
- Keep exactly: "Whoever took them... check their feet." It points the kids at the footprint clue.

Words in [brackets] are yours to adjust. Say them naturally, without the brackets.

(Sit. Whisper the entire thing, as if you're still in the library. Look just beside the camera.)

(whispering) I know I don't have to whisper. It's a habit.

Where was I at [2:15] yesterday? [Shelving]. I [shelve] from [2:00 to 2:30] every day. Alone. In the back. With no witnesses.

(pause)

That sounded worse than I meant it to.

Did I see anyone near Mrs. Driscoll's room? I saw someone in the hallway. Moving quickly. Carrying something. Wearing [orange].

(beat. If you're wearing it, look down at your clothes. If not, close your eyes.)

...I was wearing [orange].

(pause)

Do I like squishies? I love squishies. I have a squishy [on every cart]. They're very good for stress. [Shelving] is stressful. People put books back in the wrong place on purpose.

(beat. Realize how all of that sounded.)

So, to summarize: I had motive, I had access, and I was wearing [orange].

(long pause)

I'd like to amend my earlier statements.

(beat)

No. I did not take the squishies. But if I had, they would be [alphabetized] by now.

(lean in toward the camera, whisper even quieter)

One more thing for the detectives. Whoever took them... check their feet.

(sit back)

I don't know why I said that. I just felt like a detective would say that.

(Stand, push the chair in silently, walk out of frame. Stop recording.)